

ANDEAN YUNGAS

A species-rich forest reaching into the clouds

The Andean yungas ecoregion covers the eastern slope of the Andes mountain range, from 3,300–11,500 ft (1,000–3,500 m). It is sandwiched between the lowlands of the Amazon basin and Gran Chaco grasslands to the east and the high plateau of the Andean altiplano to the west. The yungas features dramatically varied topography with high ridges and steep-sided valleys created by mountain rivers. The range in altitude produces different climatic zones, which in turn create various habitat types, including moist lowland forest, deciduous and evergreen upland forests, and subtropical cloud forests.

A hotspot for diversity

Among the more than 3,000 species of plants are tree ferns, bamboo, Peruvian pepper trees, and the coca bush. Coca leaves have been chewed or brewed as a tea for centuries by the people of the Andes to counter the

effects of altitude sickness. In addition to the vast array of plants, around 200 species of vertebrate live here. The Andean yungas is known as a biological hotspot because it is home to many endemic species and because species from neighboring ecoregions—such as the Amazon rainforest—also live here.

Native species are often restricted to “altitudinal belts,” which means they are only found at certain altitudes, either because they cannot physically cross certain geographic barriers such as rivers or mountains, or they only eat vegetation that grows at certain altitudes.



SMALL STRANGER

With a population of around 350–1,000, the long-whiskered owl was discovered in 1976 in Peru. It measures just 6 in (15 cm) in height. Its whiskery face inspired the Latin name of its genus, *Xenoglaux*, which means strange owl.

Many species unique to the region

RECENT DISCOVERY
New species are still being discovered in the yungas. This dead-leaf toad is so-called because its body shape and coloration is perfectly camouflaged against dead leaves on the forest floor. It was described and named in 2014.



DEAD-LEAF TOAD

3,000 plant species

New species still being found

ORCHID HAVEN

The yungas contains 200 species of orchid, with a high level of endemism. They are particularly numerous in cloud forests as damp conditions allow epiphytes to thrive on tree trunks and branches. There are also lithophytes that grow on rocky cliffs.



MONKEY ORCHID

